

SPECIAL PROGRAMS AND ACADEMIES

In support of the mission of Loudoun County Public Schools, the School Board promotes and supports the development of special programs or academies that will align with the LCPS strategic framework. Special programs or academies are any programs that are not part of the standard approved program of studies, or which deviates from School Board policy or regulation. Special programs and academies must follow the process outlined in this policy before being approved or implemented and must be approved by the School Board before implementation. The type of credit students receive depends on the specific course offerings. The Superintendent shall develop regulations and internal guidelines for the implementation of processes outlined in this Policy.

A. Guiding Principles for New and Continuing Special Programs or Academies. To ensure fiscal responsibility for special programs or academies initiation including capital improvement, implementation, and continuation, the School Board supports the following guiding principles:

1. Equitable access across the School Division shall be demonstrated in the special program or academy proposal.
2. A variety of age-appropriate programs and academies at different grade levels should be considered. Appropriate progression in program areas across grade levels should be considered when applicable.
3. The program or academy shall align to the LCPS Strategic Framework, division goals and core beliefs.
4. The program or academy shall provide students with learning experiences that expand upon their interests, talents, and strengths, and prepare students for post-secondary college and careers.
5. The program or academy shall support student interest, be viable and sustainable over time, and be fiscally responsible.

B. Process for Special Program or Academy Proposal Development. The Program Proposal shall set forth goals and objectives and include a defined evaluation and budget plan to ensure the goals and objectives, and budgetary considerations are met. All Program Proposals shall include a timeline for implementation and a sunset provision whereby the School Board must take action to continue or expand the program or academy.

C. Process for Special Program or Academy Proposal Evaluation Review. The Special Program or Academy Proposal Evaluation Process will be further outlined under Regulation 5115. Each special program or academy proposal must be approved by the program review committee (as defined in Regulation 5115), the Superintendent, and School Board prior to implementation. A special program or

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academy may only be initiated once the School Board approves of the proposal and allocates funding.

D. Termination of the Special Academy or Program. A special academy or program may be terminated upon the recommendation of the Superintendent to the School Board if there is a lack of interest or change in circumstance. The Superintendent and School Board will give consideration for student cohorts to complete the program sequence when recommending termination of a special academy or program.

E. Exclusions. School-sponsored programs funded by money raised at the school or provided by benefactor programs and not considered experimental programs are not subject to this policy.

If a program does not meet the requirements set forth in the Regulations Establishing Standards for Accrediting Public Schools in Virginia and is an "experimental" or "innovative" program as that term has been defined by the Virginia Board of Education, the School Board may request a waiver to Accreditation Standards for the program. If the proposed program is not "experimental" or "innovative" the program must meet all Accreditation Standards and follow the process outlined in applicable School Board policies and regulations.

Adopted: 1/11/22